Vinod's clothes were as colourful as they could possibly get and on one occasion our manager Ranbir Singh Mahendra even said to him, '*Arre India ke liye khel rahe ho, aise clown jaise dress kyun pehente ho tum? Kuch dhang ka kapda pehna karo.*' (You are playing for India. Why do you dress like a clown? You should wear some decent clothes and dress sensibly.) Not that it had any impact on Vinod, though!

Those few weeks were relatively stress-free and we spent a lot of time relaxing in each other's company. On one occasion the leg-spinner Narendra Hirwani and I were having tea in our physio Dr Ali Irani's room. Ali used to make special tea for us, with a particular kind of sugar. In the middle of our conversation Ali got a call from Ranbir Singh Mahendra, who was a vegetarian, asking if he could get him some garlic bread. After the call Ali turned all philosophical and said, 'There will come a time when you guys will be there and will think about old Ali Irani who used to take care of us and make us really nice tea.'

Hirwani and I found it funny that he had turned unnaturally thoughtful and Hirwani asked him to repeat what he had just said. Ali was reluctant to do so but when Hirwani insisted, he said it again. At this Hirwani jokingly said to Ali with reference to his efforts to keep Ranbir Singh Mahendra in good humour, '*Tu to har din 200 marta hai. India team mein tera naam pehle likha jata hai. Uske baad hamara naam aata hai.*' (You score a double hundred every day by being in the good books of the manager. Your name will come first in an Indian team and only then will our names be listed.)

In the World Cup, India failed to make the semi-finals, despite being competitive in most of the matches. We lost to England and Australia by the narrow margin of nine runs and one run respectively and our second match against Sri Lanka at Mackay on 28 February was washed out because of rain.

The high point of the tournament for us was the match against eventual winners Pakistan on 4 March 1992 at Sydney. After two consecutive defeats, we were determined to turn things round against Pakistan. Batting first, we had to negotiate a hostile spell of fast bowling from Wasim Akram. At one stage he was bowling magnificently to Vinod Kambli and, batting at the other end, I just kept telling Vinod to nudge the ball and run. We put together an important partnership and I followed it up with another with Kapil Dev, who scored a valuable 35 off just twenty-six balls. I was unbeaten on 54 at the end of the innings.